

REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING

IN SOUTHWEST ASIA AND NORTH AFRICA (SWANA)

RESEARCH STUDY TAKATOAT 2026



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Introduction

A reading of the history of feminist movements in the Southwest Asia and North Africa (SWANA) region sheds light on its diversity, and on the central role that feminists have played, and continue to play, in leading struggles against various systems of oppression and violence, including patriarchy, colonialism, neoliberalism, and racism. Feminist researchers and activists have worked across different periods of time to document, analyze, and produce knowledge on feminist organizing, while situating feminist struggles within the economic, political, and social contexts in which they are located in the process of resisting Western cooptation. As history shows, feminist struggles across multiple countries of the region are not limited to raising demands at the local level; feminists have also worked to establish networks and exchange knowledge at the regional and international levels[1] [2]. Despite the presence of such experiences, there is little research documenting this work highlighting the need for building knowledge on regional and on cross-border feminist organizing.

The need for documentation and for learning from previous experiences with regional feminist organizing is rendered more crucial in light of the challenges that are currently facing feminist movements. Over the past few years, feminist groups across the SWANA region have been confronted with a violent backlash led by Western and national governments against feminist activism, and are faced with an increase in repression and restrictions on physical and online spaces and the spread of anti-feminist campaigns. These coincided with cuts in international funding allocated for feminist organizations, which weakened organizations' ability to carry out their work. The genocidal war led by the Zionist entity on Gaza since October 2023 on the other hand marked a turning point in feminist

01 Arenfeldt, P., & Golley, N. al-Hassan. (2012). Mapping Arab women's movements: A century of transformations from within. The American University in Cairo Press.

02 Abou-Habib, L., Akil, C., & Chidiac, C. (2023). A flurry of feminist knowledge production in the SWANA region and the emergence of a robust young intersectional movement. Gender & Development, 31(2–3), 479–494. https://doi.org/10.1080/13552074.2023.2268393

activism, particularly with regards to the relationships that feminist organizations in the region hold with Western donors and governments. Several feminist groups rejected funding from donors and reconsidered their partnerships with international organizations who were either in support of, or silent about the genocide. All these factors have threatened feminist organizations' ability to remain sustainable and continue to create impact. Finally, several countries in the region, such as Yemen, Syria, Sudan, Libya, and Western Sahara continue to experience wars, colonization, and armed conflicts, which renders feminist work more challenging, further contributes to fragmentation and divisions within feminist movements.

It is in this context that this research, led by the Jordan-based feminist organization Takatoat, has emerged – aiming to contribute on one hand to the documentation of feminist regional alliance building in the SWANA region across different historical periods, and to provide an understanding of the realities shaping regional feminist organizing and alliance building. In other words, the objective of this research is twofold: the first relates to contributing to the **production of knowledge** on feminist work at the regional level, and the second is linked to **proposing practical steps** for building a regional feminist alliance, based on an understanding and an analysis of the current barriers and opportunities for building this type of work in the SWANA region. This research therefore aims to present practical measures for regional alliance building that are anchored in the material conditions of feminist work.

THE STUDY IS FOCUSED ON ANSWERING THE FOLLOWING QUESTIONS:

WHAT ARE THE REALITIES OF FEMINIST WORK IN THE SWANA REGION, AND WHAT ARE THE CHALLENGES FACED BY FEMINIST MOVEMENTS?

WHAT IS THE IMPORTANCE OF BUILDING A REGIONAL FEMINIST ALLIANCE IN THE SWANA REGION, AND HOW DO FEMINIST GROUPS ENVISION THE FORMS, STRUCTURES AND OBJECTIVES OF THIS TYPE OF ALLIANCE?

WHAT ARE THE OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES RELATED TO BUILDING REGIONAL AND CROSS-BORDER FEMINIST WORK?

WHAT ARE THE FIRST STEPS AND RESOURCES AVAILABLE FOR REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING?

Introduction

To explore these questions in depth, the study mobilizes a mixed-methods approach that includes a literature review of published research and books on the history of feminist work in the region and the building of regional feminist networks and organizations, as well as a review of reports, publications, and archives issued by research institutes and academic institutions on these same topics. Using different data collection methods, the study also gathered data from 85 feminist activists and representatives of feminist organizations and networks in the region through a questionnaire, qualitative semi-structured interviews, and a consultation session held with feminist working across the region.

This document presents the results of the research, focusing on cross-border feminist organizing, and on understanding the possibilities for carrying out this type of work. The first section includes definitions of key concepts and their applications in the context of the SWANA region, followed by an overview of the history of regional feminist alliance building and of the initiatives taken by feminists across multiple historical periods with the aim of building regional networks and alliances. The third section presents the research methodology, before delving into the findings in more depth. The final section of the research focuses on the proposed steps and recommendations for building a regional feminist alliance in the SWANA region.



01 First: Definitions And Key Concepts

DEFINITION OF FEMINISM

Tackling the topic of feminism in the SWANA region requires contextualizing the emergence of this concept across its multiple countries, as well as its definition within the boundaries of the region. As Pernille Arenfeldt and Nawar al-Hassan Golley (2012) state in the introduction of their book titled **"Mapping Arab Women's Movement"**, the word feminism does not have a single translation in Arabic, with **"nisa'i"**, or **"niswi"** as examples of used Arabic terms holding the same meaning[3]. In the introduction to the **"Intersectional feminist knowledge guide – دليل معرفي نسوي تقاطعي"** elaborated by Ibtisam Al-Atiyat, the author notes that while feminism in its current definition has roots in the region, the term is rather recent, as organizations in the region used to identify themselves as **"نسـائية"**, or primarily concerned with women's rights[4].

The absence of a single term for feminism has led opponents to use this fact as proof that feminism is a concept imported from the West. As a result, many feminists and women's rights activists in the region refrain from referring to themselves as feminists, to distance themselves from this western affiliation and avoid the related accusations that might follow of wanting to promote western agendas[5] [6]. In that sense, women in the region might be leading feminist struggles and involved in feminist acts without necessarily designating them, or themselves, as feminists. The refraining by certain activists from using the term feminism sheds light on the importance of understanding feminism beyond its Western definitions and conceptions and situating it within the geographic and historical contexts of the region[7].

03 Arenfeldt, P., & Golley, N. al-Hassan. (2012). Mapping Arab women's movements: A century of transformations from within. The American University in Cairo Press.

04 Al-Atiyat, I., Swailem, S., Mershad, H., Mouawad, N., & Khatib, I. (2023). Takatoat; Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung.

05 Ibid.

06 Arenfeldt, P., & Golley, N. al-Hassan. (2012). Mapping Arab women's movements: A century of transformations from within. The American University in Cairo Press.

07 Mohanty, C. T. (1984). Under Western Eyes: Feminist Scholarship and Colonial Discourses. Boundary 2, 12/13, 333–358. JSTOR. https://doi.org/10.2307/302821

This also sheds light on the various ways through which feminists in the SWANA region interact with and navigate the political, and social contexts in which they are located, in the process of pushing their activism forward. In line with this, the research adopts a flexible definition of feminism that is anchored in the realities of women and marginalized communities. The study will delve further into the definitions of feminism, its values and strategies as shared by feminist activists during the data collection phase.

SOUTHWEST ASIA AND NORTH AFRICA

The study uses the term **"Southwest Asia and North Africa"** to refer to countries stretching from Southwest Asia, including Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, Palestine, to the Gulf states, including Iraq, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Oman, and Yemen, as well as North African countries including Tunisia, Algeria, Morocco, Libya, Western Sahara, Sudan, and Egypt. It is important to note that the adopted definition of the SWANA region is not limited to its geographical borders and extends to include activists and organizations living outside of the region and conducting feminist work for and on the region.

It is also important to note that the countries of the region differ in their realities and in the political, economic, and social structures that shape them. For example, many countries in the region, such as Sudan, Yemen, Syria, and Libya, have faced wars, divisions, and internal conflicts during the aftermath of the Arab revolutions in 2011, and have witnessed and are still witnessing large-scale migration and displacement, in addition to a strong presence of armed militias and forces. These conflicts have led to increased repression and violence, and to divisions between feminist activists. In many other countries, including Lebanon, Egypt, Iraq, and Tunisia, ongoing social, economic, and political crises have worsened living conditions, compromised access to resources even further, and led to an increase in crackdowns on civil society organizations and the persecution of activists[8]. On the other hand, colonialism and occupation are still dominating the realities of some countries in the region, including Western Sahara, Palestine, Syria and Lebanon, which links the reality of feminist work to the struggle for national liberation. As for the countries of the Gulf, these are considered to be stable countries economically, politically, and security-wise, and are characterized by repressive regimes and policies and strict control over women's spaces and over civil society. This study takes these diverse contexts into account during the collection, analyses, and presentation of the data.

08 Asfari Institute for Civil Society and Citizenship. (2023). From Histories to Futures A Mapping of Feminist Movements in the MENA Region. Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung. https://asfariinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/From-Histories-to-Futures-A-Mapping-of-Feminist-Movements-in-the-MENA-Region_EN.pdf

REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING

A reading of the history of feminist movements in the region shows that feminists have always been involved in knowledge exchange and in building formal and informal partnerships and alliances throughout different historical periods[9] [10]. Our study traces the development of regional feminist organizing and alliance building during these periods, and adopts the terms **"regional feminist organizing"** and **"cross-border feminist organizing"** interchangeably to refer to the breadth of actions taken by feminist activists in the process of building regional bridges, including knowledge exchange practices, the organizing of regional events and activities, the building of alliances & networks around specific projects, and the establishing of longer term, sustainable forms of cooperation that involve the forging of a collective identity and the exchange of resources and knowledge[11]. The study will also delve into the conceptions of regional feminist organizing, as well as of its form and structures as shared by feminist activists in the region that participated in this research.

FEMINIST SOLIDARITY

The study adopts a broad definition of **"feminist movements"** that includes individuals, initiatives, organizations, groups, networks, collectives, and grassroot movements that have the promotion of gender justice and gender equality as their main objective. In order to take into account the diversity of feminist work in the region and feminist activists' different positions within patriarchal, capitalist, and racial systems of domination, the study draws on theories of **"Black feminism"** and **"transnational feminism"** which reject the definition of women as a homogeneous group and analyze the dynamics and power relations that exist between women, based on their race, class and sexual and gender identities[12] [13]. In her work on transnational feminism, the feminist scholar Chandra Talpade Mohanty criticizes and rejects definitions of transnational feminist solidarity that is based on the notion of **"shared oppression"** between women living under a patriarchal system[14]. She notes that this notion assumes that women are a homogeneous group and fails to take into consideration the different historical, economic, and social contexts that shapes the realities of women across geographic locations,

09 Abou-Habib, L., Akil, C., & Chidiac, C. (2023). A flurry of feminist knowledge production in the SWANA region and the emergence of a robust young intersectional movement. Gender & Development, 31(2–3), 479–494. https://doi.org/10.1080/13552074.2023.2268393

10 Al-Atiyat, I., Swailem, S., Mershad, H., Mouawad, N., & Khatib, I. (2023).موجودات، متضامنات، مقاومات دليل معرفي نسوي تقاطعي Takatoat; Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung.

11 Berriane, Y., & Duboc, M. (2019). Allying beyond social divides: An introduction to contentious politics and coalitions in the Middle East and North Africa. Mediterranean Politics, 24(4), 399–419. https://doi.org/10.1080/13629395.2019.1639022

12 Mohanty, C. T. (1984). Under Western Eyes: Feminist Scholarship and Colonial Discourses. Boundary 2, 12/13, 333–358. JSTOR. https://doi.org/10.2307/302821

13 hooks, bell. (1984). Sisterhood: Political Solidarity Between Women. In Feminist Theory From Margin to Center. South end Press. https://funceji.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/08/bell_hooks_feminist_theory_from_margin_to_centebookzz-org_.pdf

14 Mohanty, C. T. (2003). Feminism Without Borders: Decolonizing Theory, Practicing Solidarity. Duke University Press

and that materially shape women's positions within dominant systems and structures. Mohanty emphasizes the importance of taking the differences between women into account in the process of building collective feminist struggles.

bell hooks also expressed this view in her book **"Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center"**, rejecting the idea of a **"shared oppression"** as the basis for building solidarity among women, pointing out that women do not share similar realities and that some of them contribute to the oppression of other women. In her work, she focuses on the differences in the positions of black women and white women under the racial structures shaping the context of the United States. She argues that by constantly questioning the positions of women within different systems of oppression, it is possible to build and create collective feminist struggles that take into account their realities and experiences, and that ensure that women with privileged positions within systems of domination assume their responsibilities in fighting systems of oppression[15].

Building on these analyses, both Mohanty and hooks worked on elaborating definitions of **"solidarity"** that reject the notion of **"global sisterhood"** which they view as detached from a historical understanding of women's struggles. Mohanty mobilizes the concept of **"reflective solidarity"** put forward by Jodi Dean (1998) and that is rooted in the idea that feminist solidarity must include two key moments: the moment of opposition towards those who oppress and marginalize others, and a moment of mutual recognition of the particularity of the experiences of each oppressed group[16]. Based on this conception, Mohanty adds that solidarity cannot be built on gender alone and must include a historical and political analyses of the dominant racial and class relations between women[17]. Our study adopts the conceptions of solidarity elaborated by black and transnational feminists in its work on regional feminist solidarity across SWANA.

15 hooks, bell. (1984). Sisterhood: Political Solidarity Between Women. In Feminist Theory From Margin to Center. South end Press. https://funceji.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/08/bell_hooks_feminist_theory_from_margin_to_centebookzz-org_.pdf

16 Dean, J. (1998). Feminist Solidarity, Reflective Solidarity: Theorizing Connections After Identity Politics. Women & Politics, 18(4), 1–26. https://doi.org/10.1300/J014v18n04_01

17 Mohanty, C. T. (2003). Feminism Without Borders: Decolonizing Theory, Practicing Solidarity. Duke University Press.

INTERSECTIONALITY

The study adopts the concept of **"intersectionality"** in its understanding and analysis of feminist work in the region. This concept, elaborated by black feminists, aims to highlight the ways in which systems of oppression intersect to shape women's lives and realities. In that sense, intersectionality suggests that systems of oppression – including patriarchy, racism, and capitalism – are interlocking and need to be taken together to elaborate a more thorough understanding of women's and marginalized groups' experiences[18] [19]. This study therefore mobilizes the concept of intersectionality, taking into account the colonial, economic, social, and racial structures that shape the SWANA region, and analyzing the ways these shape women's experiences[20]. Intersectionality will also be used with the aim of avoiding the centering of mainstream feminist movements and providing space for struggles and movements led by immigrant, refugee, and non-Arab communities and to their experiences with navigating the varying systems of oppression. Finally, intersectionality will be used as a lens to understand the ways through which the struggles against different systems of oppression are integrated and addressed by feminist activists.

18 Combahee River Collective. (2006). Déclaration du Combahee River Collective. Les Cahiers Du CEDREF, 14, 53–67. https://doi.org/10.4000/cedref.415

19 Crenshaw, K. (1991). Mapping the Margins: Intersectionality, Identity Politics, and Violence against Women of Color. Stanford Law Review, 43(6), 1241–1299. https://www.jstor.org/stable/1229039

20 Mollett, S., & Faria, C. (2018). The spatialities of intersectional thinking: Fashioning feminist geographic futures. Gender, Place & Culture, 25(4), 565–577. https://doi.org/10.1080/0966369X.2018.1454404



02 Second: Literature Review

This section presents the literature review on feminist organizing in the SWANA region. It includes a review of published academic research and books on the history of feminist activism in the region and on regional feminist network building. It also includes a review of reports, publications, and archives produced by research institutes and academic institutions. **Given the lack of research on regional feminist organizing and alliance building, this work constitutes a first step towards documenting the experiences and challenges of regional feminist work & understanding the strategies & approaches adopted by feminist organizations across multiple countries in the context of regional work.**

With regards to the history of feminist activism in the SWANA region, the dominant literature focuses on key periods that have shaped feminists organizing across multiple countries – from the late 19th century until our present day – and refers to major shifts in the trajectory of regional feminist alliance building in SWANA[21] [22] [23] [24]. Between the 1920s and the 1960s, regional alliances were centered around the struggle against colonialism, the pursuit of national liberation, and the struggle for the liberation of Palestine. With the **institutionalization of feminist work in the 1970s,** led by international organizations and mainly by the United Nations, feminist demands began to be more present and visible in international conferences organized during the period known as the **"United Nations Decade for Women"** (1975-1985)[25]. Partnerships and alliances between feminist groups focused on participating in international

21 Asfari Institute for Civil Society and Citizenship. (2023). From Histories to Futures A Mapping of Feminist Movements in the MENA Region. Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung. https://asfariinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/From-Histories-to-Futures-A-Mapping-of-Feminist-Movements-in-the-MENA-Region_EN.pdf

22 Al-Atiyat, I., Swailem, S., Mershad, H., Mouawad, N., & Khatib, I. (2023). موجـودات، متضـامنات، مقـاومات دليـل معـرفي نسـوي تقاطعي . Takatoat; Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung.

23 Al Rahbi, النسوية مفاهيم وقضايا (النسخة الأولى). الرحبة للنشر والتوزيع. (2014). م. https://www.bookleaks.com/files/fhrst6/472.pdf

24 Zaatari, Z., & Joseph, S. (2023). Introduction. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 1–15). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

25 AbiYaghi, M.-N., Jagarnathsingh, A., & Yammine, L. (2019). Civil Society in Lebanon: The Implementation Trap. Civil Society Knowledge Center, Lebanon Support. https://civilsociety-centre.org/paper/civil-society-lebanon-implementation-trap

conferences and working on presenting their demands in these spaces using the **framework of international development and human rights** adopted by the United Nations. This coincided with the proliferation of non-governmental organizations that rely heavily on external funding across multiple countries of the region, a phenomenon that is known as **"NGOization"**[26]. In this context, feminist networks that were established during these periods became tied to funding, which was reflected in their structures and strategies that were more adapted to donor requirements.

The 2000s witnessed radical transformations of feminist movements across the region as a result of **the spread of social media** and the reliance of social movements on its use, particularly during the revolutions that erupted across many countries of the region starting 2011, or what is known as the **"Arab Spring"**. This shift allowed feminist organizations to connect with groups in other countries, and develop regional campaigns aimed at raising awareness on feminist issues. This has allowed for breaking isolation among women and marginalized groups, and for raising demands in the public sphere. These campaigns have continued from 2011 until recent years, with feminist groups relying on social media platforms as a primary tool for raising awareness about various issues and expressing their positions on regional topics, the most recent of which is the genocidal war on Gaza that was launched by the Zionist entity in 2023.

This study will delve further into analyzing the forms and structures of regional feminist organizing during the different periods mentioned above, as well as into the ways regional feminist organizing has interacted with the changing political, economic, and social realities of the region. The history of regional feminist organizing also reveals the repressive tactics and strategies adopted by local governments, as well as by Western powers, to weaken feminist work and strip it of its political dimension.

REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING AND THE STRUGGLE FOR NATIONAL LIBERATION

The history of feminist movements in the SWANA region is often traced back to the period of the **"Arab Renaissance"** between 1820 and 1914, during which the educated elite – particularly in Egypt, Syria, and Lebanon – began to be interested in and raise questions about modernity. At the heart of these questions was the situation of women in Arab countries, which was perceived to be the reason for the countries' backwardness compared to the West[27]. Women from the elite also took part in this intellectual movement, starting literary salons, publishing magazines dedicated to women's issues and contributing

26 Jad, I. (2004), The NGO-isation of Arab Women's Movements. IDS Bulletin, 35: 34-42. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1759-5436.2004.tb00153.x

27 AbiYaghi, M.-N., Jagarnathsingh, A., & Yammine, L. (2019). Civil Society in Lebanon: The Implementation Trap. Civil Society Knowledge Center, Lebanon Support.https://civilsociety-centre.org/paper/civil-society-lebanon-implementation-trap

to newspaper articles[28] [29]. They also established charitable organizations that focused on providing education to poorer women, and which later became platforms for raising political awareness during national liberation movements[30]. The **"Arab Renaissance"** period saw a collective production of intellectual work and an exchange of knowledge by women in different countries of the region. Women from the elite classes also took part in discussions and international conferences along with Western and European feminists[31] [32].

During this same period, women also played a crucial role in anti-colonial and struggles for national liberation across the region, through leading protests, caring for the wounded, providing information to national resistance fighters, and raising funds to support the resistance[33]. They participated in the armed struggle against colonialism, a topic that is often overlooked in the literature on feminist movements in the region. In Algeria for example, Algerian and Berber (Amazigh) women played a key role in the armed struggle against French colonial forces[34] [35]. And in Palestine, women participated in the armed struggle against Zionist gangs in 1947 across many cities. In Yafa, women formed a secret women's organization called **"Zahrat al-Uqhuwan"** (Daisy Flower), which was involved in armed struggle against the Zionist occupation until the city fell in 1948. Women also fought alongside men in Nablus and in Jenin, and in many cities, women participated in transporting weapons, digging trenches, and setting up roadblocks[36]. It is important to highlight the limited solidarity expressed by Western feminists with Arab women's struggle against colonialism, and their prevailing silence on issues related to the region[37]. This led to frustrations and feelings of discomfort among Arab feminists, as illustrated by Sara Salem in her article **"Feminist Solidarity Across National Borders: The Case of Angela Davis in Egypt"** (2018)[38]. Salem notes that Egyptian feminists grew frustrated in the period following independence from British colonialism in 1922 at the silence of Western feminists on this issue. This was also

28 L. Fleischmann, E. (2023). Women of the Middle East in the Colonial and postcolonial eras. In S. Joseph & Z. Zaatari (Eds.), Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 63–80). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

29 Al Rahbi, النسوية مفاهيم وقضايا (النسخة الأولى). الرحبة للنشر والتوزيع. (2014). م. https://www.bookleaks.com/files/fhrst6/472.pdf

30 Ibid.

31 Al Rahbi, النسوية مفاهيم وقضايا (النسخة الأولى). الرحبة للنشر والتوزيع. (2014). م. https://www.bookleaks.com/files/fhrst6/472.pdf

32 L. Fleischmann, E. (2023). Women of the Middle East in the Colonial and postcolonial eras. In S. Joseph & Z. Zaatari (Eds.), Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 63–80). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

33 Al Rahbi, النسوية مفاهيم وقضايا (النسخة الأولى). الرحبة للنشر والتوزيع. (2014). م. https://www.bookleaks.com/files/fhrst6/472.pdf

34 Ibid.

35 Sadiqi, F. (2019). Transforming North African Feminisms from Within: New Post-Arab Spring Feminist Voices. Cairo Studies in English, 2018(1), 33–53. https://doi.org/10.21608/cse.2019.33893

36 Dayan-Herzbrun, S. (2012). Chapitre 5. Femmes du Liban et de la Palestine dans la lutte armée. In Penser la violence des femmes (pp. 120–137). La Découverte; Cairn.info. https://doi.org/10.3917/dec.cardi.2012.01.0120

37 Salem, S. (2018). Intersectionality and its discontents: Intersectionality as traveling theory. European Journal of Women's Studies, 25(4), 403–418. https://doi.org/10.1177/1350506816643999

38 Ibid.

evident in relation to the violence suffered by Palestinians under British colonialism, and later during the Zionist occupation of Palestine.

These contradictions shed the light on the myth of **"global sisterhood"** and on the double standards of the West with regards to colonialism. In this context, Egyptian women turned to Arab feminists and feminists from the Global South in search for solidarity. In 1938, the Egyptian Women's Union organized the **"Eastern Women's Congress in Defense of Palestine"** in Cairo, during which Hoda Shaarawi called on Arab countries to establish their own women's unions[39]. In 1944, the Egyptian Women's Union held the first Arab Women's Conference in Cairo, which led to the establishment of the Arab Feminist Union. According to Badran (1996), the Arab Women's Conference in Cairo marked a turning point towards **"Arab feminism"** – after recognizing the limits of global feminist solidarity – and focused on the themes of nationalism and feminism[40]. The conference inspired the creation of women's unions in other countries in the region, such as the Iraqi Women's Union, founded in 1945, which was active in charitable work and in promoting women's education, and addressed various issues such as divorce, child custody, women's working conditions, and property rights[41].It is important to note that some women's unions at that time had close ties to the existing governments[42].

Countries in the region gained their independence at different periods from the 1920s with Egypt's independence from British rule in 1922, to the early 1960s with Algeria's independence from French colonialism in 1962[43]. In the context of nation-building, women's demands were sidelined and treated as secondary to national demands[44]. In Egypt, for example, women's rights were not taken into account during the drafting of the constitution, which pushed feminists – especially those from the upper classes – to organize separately from the nationalist movement and establish the Egyptian Women's Union in 1923[45]. In Lebanon, the first electoral law in 1950 did not give women the right to vote or run for office in parliament [46]. Feminist groups continued to put pressure and raise demands for their rights across various independent states, focusing on the right to education and political

39 L. Fleischmann, E. (2023). Women of the Middle East in the Colonial and postcolonial eras. In S. Joseph & Z. Zaatari (Eds.), Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 63–80). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

40 Badran, M. (1996). Feminists, Islam, and Nation: Gender and the Making of Modern Egypt. (Course Book ed.). Princeton: Princeton University Press. https://muse.jhu.edu/book/29615.

41 Ali, Z. (2019). Feminisms in Iraq: Beyond the Religious and Secular Divide. Gender a Výzkum/ Gender and Research, 20(2), 47–67. https://www.genderonline.cz/pdfs/gav/2019/02/03.pdf

42 L. Fleischmann, E. (2023). Women of the Middle East in the Colonial and postcolonial eras. In S. Joseph & Z. Zaatari (Eds.), Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 63–80). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

43 Akbarzadeh, S. (Ed.). (2023). Handbook of Middle East Politics. Edward Elgar Publishing. https://doi.org/10.4337/9781802205633

44 Al Rahbi, النسوية مفاهيم وقضايا (النسخة الأولى). الرحبة للنشر والتوزيع. (2014). ص. https://www.bookleaks.com/files/fhrst6/472.pdf

45 Praveen, N., Ahmed, Z., & Qureshi, T. (2020). A History Of Feminist Discourse And Arab Uprising In Egypt. 19(3), 5179–5188. https://doi.org/10.17051/ilkonline.2020.03.735663

46 Daou, B. (2015). Feminisms in Lebanon: After proving loyalty to the "Nation", will the "Body" rise within the "Arab Spring"? Civil Society, 1. https://civilsociety-centre.org/file/feminismsinlebanonafterprovingloyaltyenpdf/download?token=fPid7vbA

participation, as well as on reforms to personal status laws [47]. Women were more successful in securing the right to vote in most Arab countries; however, personal status laws remained unchanged. An exception was Tunisia where polygamy was abolished, women were allowed to file for divorce, and women's child custody rights were expanded[48].

REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING AND THE LIBERATION OF PALESTINE

The 1950s and the 1960s were characterized by the strong presence of leftist movements in multiple countries of the region, including Tunisia, Egypt, Lebanon, Syria and Iraq. These movements, as well as the feminist movements that were present at the time, placed the liberation of Palestine at the heart of their work in the aftermath of the Nakba in 1948 during which over 700,000 Palestinians were expelled from their land by the Zionist occupation and many of whom became refugees in neighboring countries such as Lebanon, Jordan and Syria[49]. Feminist movements therefore gathered their efforts to support Palestinian refugees & were engaged in the struggle for Palestinian liberation[50] [51] [52]. The literature on feminist organizing during this period focuses on feminist solidarity movements with Palestine that were present in countries like Lebanon, Jordan, Yemen, and Sudan[53] [54] [55] [56]. In Yemen for example, women organized protests in Aden against the British support to Zionist presence and expansion in Palestine, and in Jordan the Arab Women's Federation (AWF) – established by Jordanian middle and upper class women in 1954 – called for the engagement in the struggle for the liberation of Palestine, with many of its members participating in protests against Zionist occupation and demanding first aid trainings for women, as well as access to

47 Asfari Institute for Civil Society and Citizenship. (2023). From Histories to Futures A Mapping of Feminist Movements in the MENA Region. Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung. https://asfariinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/From-Histories-to-Futures-A-Mapping-of-Feminist-Movements-in-the-MENA-Region_EN.pdf

48 Asfari Institute for Civil Society and Citizenship. (2023). From Histories to Futures A Mapping of Feminist Movements in the MENA Region. Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung. https://asfariinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/From-Histories-to-Futures-A-Mapping-of-Feminist-Movements-in-the-MENA-Region_EN.pdf

49 Sa'di, A. H., & Abu-Lughod, L. (2007). Nakba: Palestine, 1948, and the Claims of Memory. Columbia University Press; JSTOR. http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.7312/sadi13578

50 Brand, L. A. (1998). Women and the State in Jordan: Inclusion or Exclusion? In Y. Yazbeck Haddad & J. L. Esposito (Eds.), Islam, Gender, and Social Change (pp. 100–123). NY: Oxford University Press.

51 Daou, B. (2015). Feminisms in Lebanon: After proving loyalty to the "Nation", will the "Body" rise within the "Arab Spring"? Civil Society, 1. https://civilsociety-centre.org/file/feminismsinlebanonafterprovingloyaltyenpdf/download?token=fPid7vbA

52 Kallah, M. (2023). Arab Feminism and the Hijab: Exploring the Intersection of Feminism and Islam in Jordan [Independent Study Project (ISP) Collection]. https://digitalcollections.sit.edu/isp_collection/3701

53 Al-Ashtal, A. N. (2023). A Long, Quiet, and Steady Struggle: The Women's Movement in Yemen. In Z. Zaatari & S. Joseph (Eds.), Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st Edition, pp. 197–251). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

54 Badran, M. (1996). Feminists, Islam, and Nation: Gender and the Making of Modern Egypt. Princeton University Press.

55 Daou, B. (2015). Feminisms in Lebanon: After proving loyalty to the "Nation", will the "Body" rise within the "Arab Spring"? Civil Society, 1. https://civilsociety-centre.org/file/feminismsinlebanonafterprovingloyaltyenpdf/download?token=fPid7vbA

56 Kallah, M. (2023). Arab Feminism and the Hijab: Exploring the Intersection of Feminism and Islam in Jordan [Independent Study Project (ISP) Collection]. https://digitalcollections.sit.edu/isp_collection/3701

arms. The Arab Women's Federation had also links with Algerian feminist movements that were involved in the fight against French colonial rule[57].

With regards to transnational efforts led by feminists during this period, an article published by **"Focus on the Global South"** sheds light on the anti-imperialist feminist movement that emerged within the context of the Global South between the 1950s and the 1960s in the wake of the Bandung conference that took place in Indonesia in 1955[58]. The article documents the steps and efforts led by feminists in countries across Asia and Africa who came together to reject Western feminist agendas, and work on developing South-South solidarities. These included making links between feminist struggles and anti-colonial struggles and engaging in discussions on the positions of different feminists in the Global North and the Global South, and the different strategies they could adopt accordingly in the process of fighting colonialism[59]. Efforts also included the organization of the Afro-Asian Women's Conference in Cairo in 1961, which was attended by leftist, nationalist, and state feminists from both continents to discuss the role of women in liberation struggles and to raise demands related to women's political and economic rights. A number of Arab countries participated in this conference, including Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia, Libya, Sudan, and Egypt[60].

THE "UN DECADE FOR WOMEN" AND ITS IMPACT ON REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING

With the rise of Islamist & authoritarian regimes in the 1970s, repression against leftist, feminist, and student movements intensified across the region[61]. The defeat of Arab states in the 1967 war against Israel, combined with ongoing political and economic instabilities, contributed to a shift in state policy towards the adoption of neoliberal economic reforms and reductions in public spendings[62].

In parallel, the 1970s witnessed a series of international conferences organized by United Nations agencies that focused on advancing women's rights. This period known as the **"United Nations Decade for Women"** (1975–1985) [63] [64], marked

57 Kallah, M. (2023). Arab Feminism and the Hijab: Exploring the Intersection of Feminism and Islam in Jordan [Independent Study Project (ISP) Collection]. https://digitalcollections.sit.edu/isp_collection/3701

58 Putri, S., & Aziziah, N. (2025, April 17). Unmasking Memories of Feminist Anti-Imperialist Movement: Where Were the Women in Bandung Conference? [Online post]. Focus on the Global South. https://focusweb.org/unmasking-memories-of-feminist-anti-imperialist-movement-where-were-the-women-in-bandung-conference/

59 Ibid.

60 Baldinetti, A., & Biondi, M. (2025). Unfolding Transnational Female Networks: Algeria, Libya, Morocco, and Tunisia's delegates at the first Afro-Asian Women's Conference (1961). Journal of Asian and African Studies, 60(2), 895–909. https://doi.org/10.1177/00219096231179657

61 Mojab, S. (2023). Women and Revolution in the Middle East. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 197–211). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

62 Alsaba, K., & Kapilashrami, A. (2016). Understanding women's experience of violence and the political economy of gender in conflict: The case of Syria. Reproductive Health Matters, 24(47), 5–17. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.rhm.2016.05.002

63 AbiYaghi, M.-N., Jagarnathsingh, A., & Yammine, L. (2019). Civil Society in Lebanon: The Implementation Trap. Civil Society Knowledge Center, Lebanon Support. https://civilsociety-centre.org/paper/civil-society-lebanon-implementation-trap

a significant shift in feminist and women's rights work through its incorporation into international development and human rights frameworks that become the main references for addressing gender justice agendas[65]. This period also witnessed the promotion of advocacy-based approaches that focused on legal reform as the most effective pathway to achieving gender justice.

These transformations coincided with the proliferation of non-governmental organizations (NGOs) that relied on donor funding and operated according to donors' set agendas and requirements[66 67 68]. This phenomenon, which intensified in the 1990s & became known as **"NGOization"**, transformed feminist activism into professional and institutionalized work that is focused on the implementation of specific projects, and the achievement of defined indicators[69]. Feminist activists therefore became professionals with a set of competences and skills that are required for completing the work. It is important to note that NGOisation did not occur in the same way in all of the countries of the region; it was the most pronounced in countries like Yemen, Jordan, Palestine, Iraq, Egypt and Lebanon, while the Gulf countries appeared to have remained almost immune to this phenomenon[70].

These developments pushed women's rights organizations in the region to form regional alliances to prepare for international conferences organized during the United Nations Decade for Women, including the Beijing Conference in 1995. A number of women's rights organizations were also founded specifically for this purpose, such as the Jordanian National Commission for Women (JNCW) which was established in 1992, a few years before the Beijing Conference[71]. This context also led to the establishing of regional networks concerned with women's rights, such as the Collectif Maghreb Égalité 95, which was founded as a coalition of feminist organizations in Algeria, Morocco, and Tunisia, and focused on advocacy and lobbying for legal reforms related to personal status laws[72 73]. The spaces

64 Zaatari, Z., & Joseph, S. (2023). Introduction. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 1–15). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

65 Zaatari, Z., & Joseph, S. (2023). Introduction. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 1–15). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

66 AbiYaghi, M.-N., Jagarnathsingh, A., & Yammine, L. (2019). Civil Society in Lebanon: The Implementation Trap. Civil Society Knowledge Center, Lebanon Support. https://civilsociety-centre.org/paper/civil-society-lebanon-implementation-trap

67 Jad, I. (2010). L'ONGisation des mouvements de femmes arabes. Graduate Institute Publications, In Verschuur, C. (Ed.),. https://doi.org/10.4000/books.iheid.5919

68 Zaatari, Z., & Joseph, S. (2023). Introduction. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 1–15). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

69 Jad, I. (2010). L'ONGisation des mouvements de femmes arabes. Graduate Institute Publications, In Verschuur, C. (Ed.),. https://doi.org/10.4000/books.iheid.5919

70 Arenfeldt, P., & Golley, N. al-Hassan. (2012). Mapping Arab women's movements: A century of transformations from within. The American University in Cairo Press.

71 Al-Atiyat, I., Swailem, S., Mershad, H., Mouawad, N., & Khatib, I. (2023). موجودات، متضامنات، مقاومات دليل معرفي نسوي تقاطعي. Takatoat; Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung.

72 Abou-Habib, L. (2020). The journey began in 1995: How Beijing shaped 25 years of feminist activism. Gender & Development, 28(2), 299–313. https://doi.org/10.1080/13552074.2020.1757892

73 Zaatari, Z., & Joseph, S. (2023). Introduction. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 1–15). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

created by international conferences for feminists from across the region to meet, also led to the establishing of regional feminist organizations. In her article entitled **"How the Beijing Conference Shaped Twenty-Five Years of Feminist Activism"** (2020), Lina Abu Habib recounts how these meetings led to the founding of the **"Research and Training Group for Feminist Action"** (CRTD-A) in 1999, a regional feminist organization that aimed to integrate women's rights into development policies and programs in the region[74]. The organization brought together partner groups from Morocco, Tunisia, Algeria, Syria, Lebanon, Palestine, Jordan, and Bahrain, to work on women's right to pass on their nationality to their children.

Within the same context, an article published in Al-Raida magazine highlights a number of regional conferences organized during this period by women and human rights groups, including: the International Conference of the General Federation of Iraqi Women, held in Baghdad in 1980[75], the Second Regional Conference of Women of the Gulf Countries in Kuwait in 1981, and the Arab Women's Conference in Amman in 1983. These conferences resulted in the publication of studies on the status of women in the region by a number of academic institutions & research centers, including the Institute for Women's Studies in the Arab World in Beirut, Cairo University, the Center for Women's Studies at Al-Azhar University, the University of Jordan, Kuwait University, and others. These efforts also contributed to the publication of the book Sisterhood is Global, which addressed the situation of women in 70 countries around the world[76].

TRANSFORMATIONS FOR REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING IN THE WAKE OF THE ARAB REVOLUTIONS

The 2000s were marked by the intensification of neoliberal policies by governments across the region, and by heightened levels of repression against social and political movements, particularly in the aftermath of the 2003 U.S. invasion of Iraq[77] [78] [79]. During this period, feminist activists and women's rights organizations began to focus their work on various topics some of which have not necessarily been widely tackled before, including sexual health and reproductive rights, sexuality, bodily autonomy in addition to

74 Abou-Habib, L. (2020). The journey began in 1995: How Beijing shaped 25 years of feminist activism. Gender & Development, 28(2), 299–313. https://doi.org/10.1080/13552074.2020.1757892

75 Al-Raida. (1985, November 1). Al-Raida, III(34).

76 Al-Raida. (1985, November 1). Al-Raida, III(34).

77 Sadiqi, F. (2019). Transforming North African Feminisms from Within: New Post-Arab Spring Feminist Voices. Cairo Studies in English, 2018(1), 33–53. https://doi.org/10.21608/cse.2019.33893

78 Monier, E. (2014). The Arabness of Middle East regionalism: The Arab Spring and competition for discursive hegemony between Egypt, Iran and Turkey. Contemporary Politics, 20(4), 421–434. https://doi.org/10.1080/13569775.2014.968474

79 Zaatari, Z., & Joseph, S. (2023). Introduction. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 1–15). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

gender-based violence. The first decade of the 2000s also witnessed the emergence of numerous queer groups in the region, initially in Lebanon and Palestine, followed by Tunisia, Sudan, and Egypt[80].

Between 2010 and 2011, a wave of revolutions erupted across several Arab countries demanding the overthrow of entrenched authoritarian regimes. Protests began in Tunisia in late 2010 and spread to Egypt, Libya, Morocco, Syria, Bahrain, & Yemen. While the uprisings culminated in successful regime change in some countries, mainly Tunisia and Egypt, the situation in other countries – including Syria, Libya, and Yemen – escalated into civil wars and internal armed conflicts fueled and supported by Western imperialist powers and by regional governments, the devastating consequences of which still persist to this day[81]. In 2019, countries like Lebanon, Sudan, and Algeria witnessed new waves of protests demanding improved living and economic conditions[82][83]. The social movements across the region were characterized by the widespread participation of young people and women. Although Western media portrayed women's participation during these uprisings as a new phenomenon, feminist activists considered this participation to be a natural extension of women's engagement in feminist and political work[84].

Feminist movements have also undergone radical transformations across the region as a result of the spread of social media and its prevalent use by social movements. Feminist groups relied on social media to organize, put forward their demands, and connect with feminists across multiple countries. Social media has also provided space for women to raise their demands in countries where repression is high, and where this was not previously possible[86]. In Saudi Arabia, for example, a group of activists launched a campaign on Twitter in 2019 calling for an end to the male guardianship system (Nitham al Wilaya), which gives male relatives legal authority over women & restricts their freedoms and choices[87]. Thousands of women joined the campaign using the hashtag #معًا_لإنهاء_ولاية_الرجل_على_المرأة (#Together_to_End_Male_Guardianship_over_Women), sharing their personal experiences with the male guardianship system and demanding its

80 Ibid.

81 Zaatari, Z., & Joseph, S. (2023). Introduction. In Routledge handbook on women in the Middle East (1st ed., pp. 1–15). Routledge Taylor & Francis Group. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315165219

82 Tønnessen, L., & Al-Nagar, S. (2024). Women, Revolution, and Backlash: Igniting Feminist Mobilization in Sudan. Politics & Gender, 20(2), 495–500. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1743923X22000708

83 G. Karam, J., & Majed, R. (2023). Framing the October Uprising in Lebanon An Unfolding Revolutionary Situation. In The Lebanon Uprising of 2019: Voices from the Revolution (pp. 1–13). Bloomsbury Publishing.

84 Al-Atiyat, I., Swailem, S., Mershad, H., Mouawad, N., & Khatib, I. (2023). موجودات, متضامنات, مقاومات دليل معرفي نسوي تقاطعي. Takatoat; Friedrich-Ebert Stiftung.

85 Ibid.

86 Abou-Habib, L., Akil, C., & Chidiac, C. (2023). A flurry of feminist knowledge production in the SWANA region and the emergence of a robust young intersectional movement. Gender & Development, 31(2–3), 479–494. https://doi.org/10.1080/13552074.2023.2268393

87 Al Shahri, M., & M., N. (2020, April 1). الحركة النسوية في السعودية [Online post]. مرايا. https://elmaraya.net/ar/blogs/%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%AD%D8%B1%D9%83%D8%A9-%D8%A7%D9%84%D9%86%D8%B3%D9%88%D9%8A%D8%A9-%D9%81%D9%8A-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B3%D8%B9%D9%88%D8%AF%D9%8A%D8%A9

abolition. The campaign faced severe repression from the Saudi authorities, who arrested and tortured a number of activists.

At the regional level, feminist activists and organizations from several countries organized a cross-border women's strike in 2022 under the hashtag # تضامن_عابر_للحدود (#Cross_Border_Solidarity). The cross-border feminist strike was launched following the murders of Naira in Egypt and Iman in Jordan, which revealed a disturbing shift in patterns of violence against women, characterized by the increasing frequency of its overt enactment in the public sphere. The call for the strike emerged as a direct response to this escalation in gender-based violence and articulated a collective stance that rejects the framing of violence against women as a series of isolated incidents and recognizes it as a structural phenomenon requiring cross-border feminist action. The idea of launching a regional campaign was brought forward initially by members of Takatoat, who saw the need to organize a coordinated collective action to confront these crimes. Within this context, Takatoat reached out to feminist groups in a number of countries with a call for building a regional action. Countries included Egypt, Palestine, Sudan, Lebanon, Algeria, and Yemen, to organize a cross-border women's strike.

The cross-border strike was characterized by its horizontal and decentralized structure that relied on chain communication where Takatoat was coordinating action with local organizations across multiple countries, which in their turn were also coordinating with other local and feminist groups. This approach allowed for wide reach during the short period of preparation time which did not exceed a month. Participating organizations held over 150 coordination meetings to define the objectives of the strike, the general direction of this collective action, and the strategies that will be adopted. Each organization was left to decide its own modes of action depending on their specific contexts. Feminist organizations across the region participated in the strike in multiple ways: in Jordan, Lebanon, Egypt, Yemen, and Palestine, feminists organized protests, while in Sudan, activists organized convoys that joined ongoing protests that took place within the context of the popular uprising at the time. In Algeria, groups chose to organize art exhibitions highlighting the killing of women. There was a deliberate decision made by feminist organizations not to use any logos in communication related to the strike. The lack of a unified slogan, and the absence of the organizations' logos in communication related to the strike, reflected the grassroots aspect of this action and its decentralized structure.

The Takatoat team shared a number of challenges that were faced during the preparations and the implementation of the strike. These included security-related challenges whereby a number of activists were called in for questioning by local authorities, and others received threats on social media. Other challenges included disparities in resources between feminist organizations, experiences of exclusion, & the dominance of stronger voices in digital spaces - resulting in tensions

between feminist groups. Additionally, the short preparation time proved to be a real challenge, in the sense that it prevented participating organizations from being able to do long-term planning, and from conducting proper documentation of the various stages of the action. Despite this, a number of important lessons can still be drawn from this experience including; the importance of working in decentralised manner, and of adapting a flexible approach for organizing and coordination and the importance of responding quickly to emerging and urgent feminist topics.

This experience has also further highlighted the fact that violence against women is not a local issue, but is rather a common phenomenon that is shared across borders, & that cross-boarder solidarity is not a luxury but rather an effective tool of resistance.

Lessons learned also include the need to develop a common charter that elaborates shared definitions and conceptions of relevant feminist topics and issues and an ethical framework for the functioning of the group. Additionally, the experience sheds light on the need to elaborate a strategy and an action plan addressing potential risks faced by activists and feminist groups and ensuring their protection and the sustainability of the action. Finally the collective work on organizing the cross-border strike emphasised the importance of documentation as a tool for learning and for transferring knowledge and expertise to groups seeking to engage in similar work in the future. The cross-border feminist strike represented a significant moment in regional feminist activism, combining digital organisation with street presence and creating a shared space despite differences in context. Most importantly, it demonstrated the capacity of feminist groups to transfer anger into collective action and to build support networks that transduce geographical borders, confronting deeply entrenched systems of violence. To delve further into the organizational aspect of the strike, Brewnen Mehta (2024) carried out a study in which she analyzed the alliances that were formed within the framework of the **#Cross_Border_Solidarity** campaign, and the challenges that were faced throughout this process[88]. In line with the challenges presented above, some of the findings highlighted the fact that participants did not have shared definitions of some of the concepts relevant to the campaign – including definitions of the **"Middle East and North Africa"** region, **"feminist solidarity"** and definitions of **"gender-based -violence"**. Finally and in line with the challenges identified by Takatoat, Mehta pointed to the tensions and divisions that resulted from the dominance of digital by certain feminist organizations, namely the regional and larger ones, which contributed to the exclusion of smaller and more local organizations.

88 Mehta, B. (2024). 'Solidarity Across Borders': Online gender activism and the construction of a Middle East and North African regional public space. Gender & Development, 32(1–2), 547–573. https://doi.org/10.1080/13552074.2024.2351302

REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING SINCE OCTOBER 7, 2023

Since the launching of the Zionist entity's genocidal war on Gaza in October 2023, feminist groups across the region have been confronted with a new political reality that has pushed some to redefine their priorities and their relationships with donors and international organizations. Numerous organizations have publicly demanded an end to the killing in Gaza and have condemned the silence of Western and international feminist organizations on the genocide[89] [90]. These contradictions have exposed the double standards that are present within global feminist spaces and discourse, particularly when it comes to the topic of colonialism and occupation. Feminist groups and platforms in the region have issued public statements on social media, organized forums and discussions, and called for general strikes in protest to the ongoing genocide. Such actions have contributed to the emergence of a renewed anti-colonial feminist discourse that emphasized the interconnectedness between feminist struggles and struggles against colonialism.

Many feminist and queer organizations that have publicly expressed support for Palestine, and for the right to armed resistance, found themselves confronted to the realities of donor funding whereby they had their funding suspended by international donors linked to governments that support the genocide[91]. In their turn, some feminist organizations decided to end collaborations with certain donors whose position was in support of the genocide. As these developments continue to unfold, this study seeks to examine the impact of the genocidal war on feminist organizing in the region and to assess the implications for building regional feminist alliances within this shifting political context.

89 Takataoat. (2024). UN Women Another Shameful Statement [Instagram post]. https://www.instagram.com/p/C2e1VOFMEXH/?utm_source=ig_web_copy_link&igsh=MzRlODBiNWFlZA==

90 Mahadeen, E. (2025). Arab Feminist Cyber Activism: Theorizing Indigenous Knowledge Production and Decolonizing Feminism. Middle East Journal of Culture and Communication, 17(4), 374–388. https://doi.org/10.1163/18739865-01704006

91 مجلة كحل (2025)

03 Third: Research Methodology

The study was developed using a **mixed-methods approach** that included a review of published research, academic papers and books on **the history of feminist activism** in the SWANA region and on regional feminist organizing, as well as a review of reports, publications, and archives made public by think tanks and research institutes on the same topics. Additionally, **primary data was collected** over a period of two months between July and August 2025 through various methods, including the dissemination of a **questionnaire that aimed to gather data on the realities of feminist activism** in the region, and on the current social, political and economic context shaping feminist activism across multiple countries. The survey also delved into understanding the engagement of feminist organizations in regional feminist work and alliance building, their definitions of regional feminist organizing as well as their conception of its structures and priorities, and finally their perspectives on the ways through which regional collective feminist organizing can be built taking into consideration the various contexts of the region. **The questionnaire was disseminated among at least 250 feminist activists** and organizations that have experience conducting feminist work in the SWANA region. Feminist groups that are based outside of the geographic borders of the region and who are carrying work on and for the region were also included. **From the total of activists and organizations reached, an overall of 30 participants completed the questionnaire**.

In addition to the survey, data was gathered through a series of **qualitative semi-structured interviews** that **were conducted with 15 activists** involved in feminist work in the region. **The interviews were elaborated based on the findings from the survey** and delved further into participants' perspectives on the realities of regional feminist work, the barriers and opportunities for feminist collective organizing, the structures, feminist values and priorities according to which this type of work can be carried out, and the steps required for building regional feminist work. The interviews were conducted mainly **in Arabic and were recorded and transcribed for data analysis**. **Participants' anonymity and confidentiality were maintained** throughout the study in the process of ensuring their safety.

Finally, **a consultation session was also organized by Takatoat with over 40 feminist activists** from the region within the context of the **Feminist Forum** that was held by the organization in July 2025. The forum **aimed at providing space for feminist activists from the region to exchange knowledge, experiences and strategies, and to discuss topics related to collective feminist organizing at the regional level** including feminist accountability, funding strategies and regional and cross-border feminist organizing. During the consultation session, activists were invited to share their own perspectives on the challenges facing regional feminist organizing, and on the resources and knowledge required for building regional feminist work.

03 Third: Research Methodology

A total of 85 women activists from several countries in the region participated in this study, including Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Kuwait, Yemen, Iraq, Sudan, Libya, Tunisia, Morocco, Algeria, Egypt, Lebanon, Syria, Palestine, and Jordan. **Among the challenges faced during the data collection is reaching out to feminists in occupied territories such as Western Sahara. Additionally**, challenges were also relate to the **unstable political situation in the region** during the implementation of the research with multiple countries experiencing wars against the backdrop of the ongoing genocide in Gaza since October 7, 2023. This has resulted in slow response from participants & low levels of availabiltiy.

The following section presents the findings from the data collection phase including the questionnaire, interviews, and consultation session. The first part focuses on the definitions shared by feminist activists of feminism and feminist work within their different contexts, and their definition of the Southwest Asia and North Africa region. This is followed by a presentation of participants' perspectives of the realities of feminist work in the region and the challenges faced in recent years during the implementation of their work. In the last section, findings shed light on participants' conceptions and understanding of cross-border and regional feminist organizing, its structures, goals, values and priorities. The section also presents activists' perspectives on the resources and needs required to build regional feminist work, and on the first steps that must be taken in this direction.

04 Fourth: Data Analysis and Findings

AN OVERVIEW OF PARTICIPANTS' PROFILES

Participants in the study include feminist activists and feminist groups and organizations that are involved in feminist work in the SWANA region – whether at the local or regional levels – for at least five years.

Among the participants

45% Represent NGOs

27% Independent Activists

05% Representatives of Regional Feminist Networks

Participants also included representatives of online feminist platforms as well as feminists working within academic institutions.

A rate of **70%** **of participants indicated that they are involved in regional feminist networks** including but not limited to the Regional Coalition of Women Human Rights Defenders (WHRD MENA), the Karama Network for ending violence against women and girls, and FEMENA network that works to support feminist movements across the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) Region and in Asia.

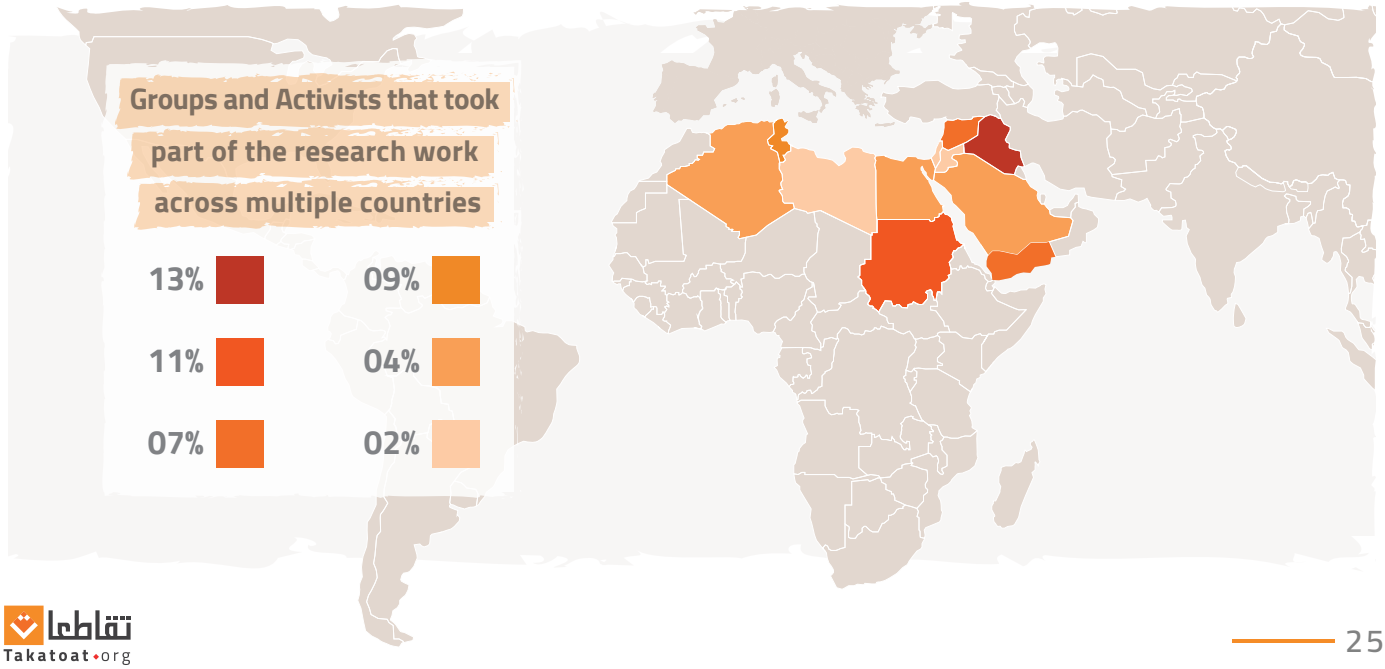
Concerning the period of work of the feminist organizations that participated in the research

48% of the participating NGOs and networks were established following the Arab revolutions in 2011

21% began their work during the last five years.

With regards to the goals and objectives of participating organizations, these were diverse and include fighting violence against women and marginalized groups, advocacy for gender justice and equality, documentation of human rights violations, provision of psychosocial and legal support for survivors of gender-based violence, provision of mental health services, legal services, economic empowerment trainings and programs, and sexual and reproductive health services for women and girls, raising awareness on economic and climate justice, producing feminist knowledge and finally, integrating feminism into media and journalism.

Groups and Activists that took part of the research work across multiple countries



As the map shows, the feminist groups and activists that took part of the research work across multiple countries, including Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Kuwait, Yemen, Iraq, Sudan, Libya, Tunisia, Morocco, Algeria, Egypt, Lebanon, Syria, Palestine and Jordan. This is in addition to the regional feminist networks and platforms that also participated in the research.

DEFINITIONS OF FEMINISM WITHIN THE CONTEXT OF THE SWANA REGION

Participants' definitions of feminism reflect their diversity in relation to their understanding of feminist work, its goals, objectives, strategies and principles as well as of the ways through which feminist activism is directly shaped by the contexts in which it emerges and is carried out. Before delving into definitions of feminism, most participants agreed on the importance of linking feminism to the local and regional contexts in which it exists and of understanding feminism as actions & knowledge that are built from the lived realities of women in the region and from their daily experiences under existing economic, political, and social systems. Participants also made the distinction between the academic and theoretical feminist knowledge and the practical feminist knowledge. The former is usually taught in universities and academic institutions, is not necessarily linked to the realities of women in the region and often implies a kind of epistemological and moral superiority. The latter is an outcome of the lived realities of women within the economic and political structures of the region, and within the structures of violence against women & marginalized groups. Participants considered the academic feminist knowledge to be exclusionary by definition of women who are not necessarily knowledgeable of feminist theories and acdemic concepts, while practical feminist knowledge is more inclusive especially of women who do not explicitly identify themselves as feminists despite leading daily feminist struggles against systems of oppression.

Overall, participants' definitions of feminism diverged into two main trends. The first defines feminism as a social justice movement that aims to achieve gender equality in line with international frameworks and guidelines for gender justice and international human rights agendas. This direction considers feminism to be a movement that aims for reforms within existing structures with the aim of achieving equal rights and justice. Participants considered the main objectives of feminism within this context to be focused on women's empowerment and capacity building for the purpose of equipping them with the skills that allow them to overcome economic and social barriers. The second trend included more radical and revolutionary conceptions that consider feminism to be a form of revolutionary struggle that aims to liberate women and marginalized groups through the dismantling of the dominant and oppressive economic, political and social structures, and throug working towards building long-term alternative structures.
Both conceptions of feminism emphasized the

importance of knowledge production in feminist work, that is grounded in the realities of women and marginalized groups in the region and that aims to transform their experiences and daily struggles as a source of knowledge and collective reflections.

As for participants' understandings of the forms & structures of feminist work, some considered feminist work and action to be a daily practice that aims to fight against and resist the marginalization that is faced by women within the patriarchal, capitalist and racist structures and across different spaces including public spaces, the workplace, academic and educational institutions, and political spaces. Others defined feminist work as an organized and structured effort, and a collective practice. As for the values and principles that were considered as crucial for building feminist work.

Participants highlighted that feminism needs to be:

Rooted in experiences and daily realities as feminism cannot be separated from the social, political, economic and cultural contexts in which it emerges, but rather stems from a deep understanding of the daily challenges and experiences of women and marginalized groups.

Intersectional in its analysis for the purpose of understanding the ways through which various systems of oppression – including patriarchal, capitalist, racist, and colonial – intersect to shape the lives of those marginalized by dominant systems of oppression.

Intersectional in its approaches and practices through integrating the knowledge of the ways systems oppression intersect and operate into feminist work and action, with the aim of transforming existing structures and refraining from reproducing systems of domination within feminist spaces.

Flexible and strategic in defining priorities and areas of work, and in elaborating strategies and approaches for confronting repressive regimes, while prioritizing the protection of feminist activists and ensuring the sustainability of feminist work.

Built on collective action and solidarity with the aim of breaking from the isolation that is dominating feminist spaces, refraining from reproducing unequal power dynamics within feminist groups and organizations, and gathering efforts in order to face systems of oppression more effectively.

Anticolonial as the current regional political context marked by the dominance of Western powers and the pressures imposed on countries from the region to normalize with Israel require that feminists clearly define their position from colonialism, occupation and imperialism.

THE REALITIES OF FEMINIST WORK IN THE SWANA REGION

When asked about the realities of feminist activism in the SWANA region, participants pointed to a series of challenges that have been affecting feminist work over the past few years. These include the increase in repressive practices by governments and the shrinking of feminist and activist spaces, the scarcity of funding for feminist organizations and the lack of sustainable and long-term funding, difficulties in long-term planning in contexts marked by conflict and war, and high levels of exhaustion & fatigue among feminist activists resulting from ongoing repression and instability.

The following sections will expand on each of these challenges. The challenges are characterized by competition for resources, the dominance of activist spaces by larger organizations, the exclusion of certain marginalized groups from feminist spaces, and ideological differences between feminists with no mechanisms for dealing with these differences. Given the importance of this last point, a separate section will be dedicated for delving into this challenge in more detail.

HEIGHTENED LEVELS OF REPRESSION AND SHRINKING FEMINIST SPACES

All participants identified the intensification of state repression as one of the primary challenges currently confronting feminist work across the region. They pointed to a growing pattern of repressive governmental practices targeting civil society actors in general, and feminist organizations & activists in particular. In many countries, activists face increasing risks of persecutions by the authorities, including risks of arrest, torture, and, in some cases, death.

Participants also pointed to an increase in hate speech against feminists, and the proliferation of a discourse that demonizes feminist activism –framing it as a threat to religious values and as a concept that is imported from the West, especially when it comes to LGBTQ rights and sexual and bodily rights. Participants gave examples of the demonization of feminist activism in countries such as Yemen, Iraq, Syria, and Libya.

In Iraq, for example, one participant referred to the political and social campaigns launched in recent years against the term **"gender"** considered as a Western concept. These campaigns also targeted other terms such as homosexuality and **"women's empowerment"**. In the Syrian context, one participant spoke about the current government's focus on promoting traditional gender roles where women are responsible for raising and educating children and performing household chores.

She highlighted that this negatively impacts the progress made by feminists in raising awareness against these stereotypes and in fighting gender-based discrimination. In Saudi Arabia, participants spoke about the restrictions and bans imposed by the government on independent gatherings organized by groups and individuals, especially over the past two years.

In most of the countries covered by the study, participants also talked about the escalation in campaigns against LGBTQ rights, driven by dominant religious ideologies and social norms that link these rights to Western agendas. Participants noted that restrictions on feminist spaces makes it impossible for activists to address topics related to sexuality and gender identity due to the repercussions this might entail. In this context, some feminists prefer to refrain from tackling these topics in public spaces all together – as a strategy for self-protection.

In addition, participants highlighted the extensive control exercised by governments over human rights organizations and their activities,

including the restrictions and control exercised over funding. In Libya, for example, one participant explained that civil society organizations are required to register officially with the authorities, who closely monitor their funding and issue permissions for activities, while retaining the power to shut down organizations at any time. Participants reported similar forms of censorship in Jordan and in Yemen, and added that governments increasingly police digital spaces, including social media.

These practices limit activists' ability to publish content on gender related topics safely, and undermine their capacity to organize, plan, and build independent and sustainable networks. Participants also expressed feelings of exhaustion, frustration, and burnout resulting from prolonged work under repressive conditions, alongside a growing sense of isolation due to their inability to communicate and build partnerships with other feminist groups.

FUNDING PRACTICES AFTER OCTOBER 7 2023

In light of the genocidal war on Gaza since October 7, 2023, feminist organizations were confronted with contradictions that marked their interactions with donors, as a result of some donor organizations' silence and in some cases support of the genocide in Gaza. These dynamics had significant repercussions for ongoing partnerships. On one hand, several Western donors suspended funding to feminist and queer organizations in the region that publicly expressed support for Palestine. On the other hand, some feminist groups chose to sever ties with specific donors as a form of political pressure. According to participants in this study, these developments also fostered new forms of collective action among feminist groups, including the issuance of joint statements articulating their positions in support of ending the genocidal war, affirming the right to armed resistance, and condemning the silence of international women's rights organizations regarding the violations and killings of women in Gaza by the Israeli occupation.

Despite the adoption of such positions publicly by a number of feminist groups, participants noted that boycott campaigns by feminist organizations were not widespread, which created divisions and tensions among these groups and limited their collective ability to exert pressure on donors and international organizations.

Participants further highlighted that these political developments have imposed a new reality on feminist work, one in which feminist activists found themselves compelled to: reassess and redefine their position as Arab feminists in the region, reconsider their relationships with certain Western organizations and governments, and critically re-evaluate dominant funding practices and structures. Participants also emphasized that this context necessitates that feminist movements redefine their goals and impact in a way that politicizes their work, arguing that any feminist organization that fails to do so risks becoming disconnected from the realities of the region.

These challenges have coincided with the global rise of the far-right movements & anti-feminist

discourse and policies, and the cuts and reductions in foreign aid and funding for international development by Western governments. These include European governments, but most importantly the United States through cuts in the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) funding for projects focused on violence against women, sexual and reproductive health and rights, and humanitarian aid. Participants noted that these measures have rendered feminist work in the region, particularly in countries that are marked by war and conflict and where the work of women's rights organizations focuses on humanitarian response and the protection of women from violence. Participants also pointed to the needs and opportunities created by this new reality of funding to develop alternative and more sustainable funding structures that would enable feminist groups to carry out independent work that is not restricted nor dictated by international donor agendas.

THE TOLL OF CONFLICTS AND WARS ON FEMINIST ACTIVISTS

Feminist movements in several countries across the region face significant challenges arising from internal conflicts and ongoing wars, which have a direct impact on the structure & sustainability of feminist work. In contexts shaped by armed conflict and emergency conditions, participants noted that priorities often shift toward addressing immediate needs and towards crisis response, resulting in the constant exhau- stion of activists. This focus on urgent demands limits the capacity of feminist activists to engage in strategic planning, develop long-term visions for sustainable organizing, and build strategic alliances with other feminist groups.

In contexts characterized by occupation, such as Palestine, these challenges are further intensified by the direct presence of occupation forces, restrictions on movement, and the ongoing and systemic violence exercised by the occupation, all of which deepen the isolation experienced by feminist groups. Participants also emphasized that conflicts and wars can exacerbate internal divisions among feminist activists due to differing political positions, thereby undermining their ability to form partnerships and engage in collective action across diverse groups. This was illustrated by one of the feminist activists in the case of Sudan, where feminist activists were divided in their positions in relation to the ongoing internal fighting that has been going on in the country since the past few years.

RELATIONSHIPS AND DYNAMICS BETWEEN FEMINIST GROUPS

During the interviews, participants shed light on internal divisions within feminist groups, which are rooted in multiple factors and pose challenges to feminist organizing. One of the main sources of these divisions, is the impact of the professionalization and NGOization of feminist work on the relationships between groups and activists – transforming them into competitive relationships over funding and resources. Participants noted that large and influential feminist organizations often dominate both funding

opportunities and feminist spaces, while smaller groups struggle to access resources. This power imbalance, they argued, hinders the building of collective and inclusive alliances.

At the level of discourse, some participants critiqued the mainstream feminist discourse that is promoted by these large organizations, and its alignment with state discourses that narrowly focus on **"women's rights"** and on the integration of women and gender within economic and political structures, without addressing the structural dimensions of systems of oppression. Activists therefore describe this discourse as limited in its transformative potential, contributing to the reproduction of dominant structures, and serving government agendas.

In addition to the competitive dynamics described above, participants highlighted the divisions among feminists that arise from disagreements on political & ideological orientations, positions from certain feminist topics, and divergences on definitions of feminism and feminist concepts. For example, feminists provided examples of existing disagreements on certain topics like collaboration with the state and state institutions, or partnerships with donors who have controversial positions on region-specific issues. Within the same context, participants shed light on disagreements among feminists on priorities and agendas, which sometimes result in the exclusion of certain topics from feminist spaces, mainly topics related to sexuality and sexual rights, sex work, and the rights and experiences of trans individuals. Finally, participants also criticized the exclusionary practices of some feminist groups toward marginalized communities within feminist spaces, arguing that such practices reproduce oppressive structures and hinder effective partnerships.

Despite ongoing efforts to build feminist networks and alliances in the region, findings indicate that such initiatives remain largely fragmented and unstructured. Networking often relies on personal relationships rather than emerging from a shared strategic vision. While participants expressed commitment to and agreed on the importance of regional alliance building, they noted a number of structural & political obstacles. These include the absence of a common political direction, the lack of common conceptions of organizational structures, significant disparities in resources and capacities, and sensitivities related to identity, historical context, and to political events shaping the context of the region. Differences in priorities and competition over funding further exacerbate divisions and limit the potential for building sustained collective action.

Participants described existing alliances as fragile & temporary, often circumstantial and limited in both duration and scope, with inconsistent communication between groups. Nevertheless, they highlighted the presence of multiple shared struggles and issues that could serve as a foundation for more structured and sustainable regional collaborations. At the same time, they stressed the urgent need for elaborating mechanisms and guidelines for collective and collaborative feminist organizing – currently lacking – and for developing feminist accountability

mechanisms that enable feminist groups to navigate differences constructively and to build sustainable, long-term alliances.

DEFINITIONS OF THE SOUTHWEST ASIA AND NORTH AFRICA REGION

Participants' responses revealed the absence of a unified definition of the Southwest Asia and North Africa (SWANA) region, as well as considerable variations in defining the common elements that are shared among the different countries of the region. They agreed on the importance of using the term **"Southwest Asia and North Africa"** as a political term that challenges Western and colonial definitions of the region, and that better accounts for its geographical and cultural diversity. Participants criticized the definitions of the region imposed by international organizations within the frameworks of their programs and projects, noting that these definitions are often disconnected from and in conflict with the region's geopolitical reality, and with definitions adopted by feminist groups themselves—for example, when some international organizations include Israel as part of the region. These externally imposed definitions were described to often serve and reflect international organizations' project-based interests and vary depending on the project with the expectations that feminist organizations will adapt to and work with these varying conceptions.

Some participants considered the Arabic language to be a unifying element, serving as a bridge for communication and knowledge exchange among most of its peoples. From this perspective, however, they noted that such a definition cannot include countries like Iran and Turkey. Within this same context, participants noted that this definition is exclusionary of non-Arabic-speaking communities, such as the Amazigh and Kurdish communities, and shed light on the importance of understanding this aspect and taking it into account when doing feminist work.

Other participants defined the region as a geographic and political space characterized by shared forms of gender-based discrimination and marginalization. In this context, women face common challenges, including legal discrimination, gender-based violence, and restrictions on personal and political freedoms. Women's realities and experiences are shaped by intersecting factors, including the dominance of patriarchal systems, economic and social inequalities, and armed conflicts. Participants viewed these intersections as a foundation for building a shared understanding of women's realities and for connecting their struggles as part of more comprehensive analyses and understandings of systems of domination and how they operate. From a feminist perspective, they argued that what unites the region is its long and rich history of feminist struggle, which can serve as a source of learning and inspiration for cross-border organizing.

Finally, some participants defined the region through its shared history of colonialism and national liberation struggles, and the shared experiences of various countries with the economic and political dominance of Western powers

and institutions over institutions and resources. They emphasized the importance of framing gender inequality & gender-based discrimination within this broader political context to better understand the realities of women and marginalized groups. In the same vein, some participants framed the region as part of the Global South, that is, the majority of the world that is subjected to Western colonialism & oppression.

FORMS AND STRUCTURES OF REGIONAL FEMINIST ORGANIZING

This section tackles regional feminist organizing as defined by feminist activists who participated in this research. It delves into participants' understanding of its importance and significance in the current context of feminist work, in addition to their conceptions of its structures, objectives, and priorities. The section also highlights previous experiences of regional feminist work, as narrated by activists who were involved in these experiences, for the purpose of both documenting such actions and providing analyses of the challenges faced and the lessons learned. Finally, the last section provides practical steps and recommendations for building regional feminist work.

With regards to participants' conceptions of regional feminist organizing, **all agreed on the importance of moving towards regional collaboration in the context of the repressive climate that is prevailing at the local, regional, and global levels.** In the same context, participants highlighted that the work around regional feminist organizing must be grounded in current needs and contribute to **addressing existing gaps** in feminist work across the region. They emphasized that this is essential **to avoid the duplication** of the work of existing alliances that are operating at the regional level.

Participants viewed the importance of building regional feminist organizing as lying in its capacity to **create spaces of support and solidarity among feminist groups,** enabling them to confront the repression and violence they face within their local contexts. At the same time, participants emphasized that regional feminist organizing plays a critical role in making links between feminist struggles across different countries in the region, which contributes towards **breaking the dominant sense** of isolation that is experience by feminist activists, building a shared foundation for collective action, **and creating spaces for the exchange** of experiences and the **production of knowledge grounded** in the region's realities. One participant, for example, referred during the interviews to the **"Uprising of Women in the Arab World"** or **"انتفاضة المرأة في العالم العربي" #** campaign launched in 2011, which illustrates how collective platforms and spaces can help disrupt the isolation women living under patriarchal structures. Although this experience was limited to a regional campaign – rather than a long-term regional alliance – it offers several lessons that can be drawn upon and applied in efforts to build regional feminist organizing, most notably the importance of decentralization & of organizing around issues that emerge from women's lived realities. The section below presents an overview of this campaign and of the main lessons learned from this experience.

An overview of the "Uprising of women in the Arab World" campaign



The **"Women's Uprising in the Arab World"** online campaign emerged in 2011 amidst the political transformations that swept the region following the Arab revolutions, as a direct response to the marginalization of women despite their active participation in popular protests. While women were at the forefront of demonstrations – sleeping in tents and chanting for the overthrow of regimes – they were met with exclusions from the political conversations that emerged at the national level. The "Women's Uprising in the Arab World' emerged as an explicit rejection of this patriarchal logic and as a declaration that women's liberation cannot be postponed nor be separated from the broader goal of political liberation.

The campaign initially emerged on the social media platform **Facebook** in late 2011, and gained momentum in October 2012, when the organizing team called on women and men across the region to participate in a campaign titled **"I Am with the Women's Uprising in the Arab World".** Participants were invited to share personal photographs holding signs expressing their support for the campaign. The initiative achieved wide circulation, with thousands of people from across Arab countries engaging with it, transforming the online platform into a collective digital space for sharing personal experiences and fostering discussion around issues of equality and discrimination.

The campaign was characterized by its spontaneous and decentralized nature. It did not emerge from structured and established feminist organizations, but rather from a shared and collective experience of anger. Through social media engagement, the campaign highlighted the striking similarities in the legal and social challenges faced by women across different Arab countries, including violence and harassment, legal restrictions, and discrimination in both public and private spheres. Over time, the page evolved into a cross-border space that contributed to the formation of a shared feminist consciousness transcending geographic and political divisions.

04 Fourth: Data Analysis and Findings

One of the key factors behind the success of the **"Women's Uprising in the Arab World"** was its ability to break women's sense of isolation within their societies and to foster a collective awareness grounded in shared experience and mutual knowledge. Communication among women through the campaign enabled them to recognize that they were not alone, and that their struggles were not individual cases but part of broader structures of violence and discrimination. In this sense, the movement played a crucial role in framing individual experiences as collective ones, while providing a relatively safe digital space for expression and participation. The movement also made feminism more accessible by offering the space for the sharing of personal narratives that are closely connected to women's everyday lives and experiences. Participation therefore did not require familiarity with complex feminist theories; their engagement in the campaign is possible through a simple post or a short video. This openness rendered the campaign non-elitist and accessible to a wide range of women.

Most participants emphasized the need for regional feminist organizing to be **political in the sense** that it **should have clear positions from systems of oppression and occupation** in the region and needs to be actively engaged in developing a discourse and actions that aim to confront these systems. Activists distinguished being **"political"** from **affiliation with political parties,** emphasizing that it refers instead to clarity of position, **responsibility, and commitment to addressing political, social, and economic issues.** Participants added that experiences over recent years have highlighted the shortcomings and forms of complicity that can result from **failing to define feminist organizing** as inherently political. Other participants had a different perspective on this matter, preferring for feminist organizing not to be political but rather focused on the achievement of equal rights in accordance with international human rights and gender equality frameworks. They considered this rights-based approach to be more **inclusive and flexible**, and to provide **space and freedom** for the activists involved to articulate their own political views and positions in line with their specific contexts. It is important to note that participants who preferred distancing feminist organizing from politics often **equated "politics" with political institutions and dominant political parties.**

As for the structure of regional feminist organizing, participants did not converge on a single conception of an organizational structure. Rather, they emphasized the importance of building a regional feminist space that is flexible, and capable of adapting to the constantly changing political and economic contexts of the region, and to respond to emerging needs in times of conflicts, wars and crises. Participants considered flexibility to be an important factor for ensuring the sustainability of regional feminist work, and its relevance to the realities of the region. This flexibility involves flexibility in the approaches and strategies adopted, as well as flexibility in defining **priorities in response to evolving issues, and flexibility in the organizational structure itself**

—favoring decentralization, horizontality, and the rotation of roles. While some participants emphasized the importance of defining a clear ideological and political direction for the regional alliance, others cautioned that doing so could result in exclusion of activists who do not necessarily identify with these directions and instead advocated for building alliances based on shared struggles and common objectives. Several participants emphasized the need for regional feminist organizing to be intergenerational and inclusive, cautioning against the risk of reproducing exclusionary dynamics and existing power structures that further marginalize already marginalized communities within the region. When asked about whether they have previously **faced exclusion from regional spaces**, **41%** of respondents responded affirmatively. This was expressed by participants from North African countries (Tunisia, Algeria, Morocco), as well as by participants from Palestine, Syria, Jordan and Iraq. **They noted that one of the main reasons behind experiences of exclusion is the dominance of certain feminist organizations over regional spaces**, their monopolization of representation and visibility, and their marginalization and exclusion of smaller or more recently established groups. This is in addition to the indirect exclusion that is experienced by feminist organizations and activists that are present in **contexts of occupation, wars and conflicts** like Palestine, Western Sahara and Sudan and who are sometimes incapable of traveling and being physically present in regional spaces. And in some countries like Syria, participants noted that exclusion is more linked to certain assumptions that are made in feminist spaces around Syrian feminist organizations and activists' positions from the ongoing internal wars and fighting in the country.

As for the priorities of regional feminist organizing, **participants linked these priorities to the current challenges** that are facing regional feminist work, including dependence of regional networks and alliances on international and donor **funding** therefore limiting their work and restricting it to donor agendas which are often not aligned with existing needs.

In the context of funding cuts, and of the contradictions that are shaping the relationships between donors and feminist organizations, participants **highlighted the urgent need for developing alternative and independent funding models that ensure the sustainability of regional feminist work.** One of the recommendations in this direction included beginning to map existing funding sources and structures in the region and learning from existing experiences of working with alternative models across contexts and regions.

On the other hand, participants tackled the challenge that is related to the **lack and absence** of mechanisms & guidelines for collective feminist work, which are essential for building regional feminist organizing based on feminist values and principles. **Such mechanisms need to cover collective decision-making practices, conflict management, and the distribution of roles among members.** Participants also emphasized the importance of developing feminist accountability mechanisms that move away from **policing and from punitive approaches,** and that allow the groups involved to build spaces that are grounded

in **trust and collaboration, and that avoid the reproduction of dominant oppressive structures.**

Finally, participants shed light on the structural and political barriers that hinder the sustainability and impact of regional feminist work, including the increase **in repressive practices against feminist** organizations, **the shrinking of feminist spaces, digital violence** experienced by activists in online spaces, and the burnout and fatigue resulting from working in these contexts of repression.

Participants therefore stressed the need for elaborating safe coordination and communication mechanisms and identifying safe platforms that are not under state surveillance, in addition to the need for centering care as a feminist political practice that contributes towards ensuring the sustainability of feminist work in the face of burnout and fatigue. **Participants shared a list of values they considered to be essential for building regional feminist work and which included intersectionality, accountability, transparency, collective work, and solidarity.** The experience of the Palestinian movement **"Tal'at" or "طالعات"** launched in 2019, as shared by one of its members and presented below, shed light on the challenges that the organization faced and, on the lessons learned mainly in relation to the importance of care.

Finally, the goals and priorities of regional feminist organizing can be summarized as per the following: **working on developing mechanisms for collective and collaborative work** between feminist organizations that are based on feminist values of intersectionality and solidarity, in the process of ensuring the sustainability of feminist work in the face of existing divisions and challenges; **elaborating mechanisms accountability and care** within feminist spaces and between organizations that are anchored in feminist principles; **elaborating safe mechanisms for communication** and coordination that center the protection of activists in physical and digital spaces; identifying and developing alternative funding models and structures that are independent and that ensure the sustainability of regional feminist work. On top of this, participants stressed the importance of commitment to regional feminist organizing in the process of making it possible and ensuring its successful and sustainable implementation.

An overview of the movement "Tal'at"



"Tal'at" movement began in 2019 in Palestine not only as a response to the increase in violence against women, but also as a political movement that aims to shed light on the colonial structures that produce and reproduce violence. In that sense, violence against women is not separate from colonial violence but rather an inherent aspect of colonialism and one of its structural outcomes. In this context, the slogan **"No homeland is free until women are free"** that was mobilized by Tala'at emphasized the inseparability of national liberation from women's liberation and recentered feminist struggles within the broader struggle for national liberation.

The movement quickly expanded to include Palestinian women in exile, particularly in Lebanon and in Europe (including Germany and the United Kingdom), This has positioned Tal'at as a model of cross-border feminist organizing. The movement sought to politicize feminist activism and to learn from organizational shortcomings that marked previous feminist organizing experiences. It succeeded in sustaining its work over an extended period of time and has become one of the most significant feminist movements in the Arab region, as well as one of the most prominent political movements in Palestine in recent years.

Tal'at faced a number of challenges including the rapid expansion of the movement under conditions of colonial violence. This has resulted in pressures to focus on external action – demonstrations, statements, and knowledge production, straining the movement's internal structure. This tension revealed a central reality in feminist liberation work: that care is not a secondary act, but rather a structure of resistance. Colonialism and capitalism rely on the exploitation of the body and its transformation into a tool of production. Consequently, building mechanisms for care, support, and solidarity among activists is an act that resists this logic. When women are subjected to violence during demonstrations, providing protection and care is not merely a security response, but a strategy of resistance against colonial violence.

The experience of Tal'at also revealed the need to redefine political time. Colonialism and capitalism impose a logic of speed, achievement, and results as criteria for success. This logic shifts political movements' focus on the achievement of results rather than on the process of organizing. The experience of Tal'at shed light on the importance of slow organizing, collective thinking, and the building of mechanisms for accountability and solidarity as necessary practices for building a movement capable of enduring structural violence. In this sense, feminist organizing would be defined as a space for producing new forms of community, where care becomes a structural element of political organizing, solidarity becomes a practice, and organizing becomes a site for liberating life from the structures that seek to manage and control it. The movement was not merely a reaction to violence, but an act that redefines the very conditions of political existence, whereby women's liberation is not the result of national liberation, but rather one of the conditions for its possibility.



05 Fifth: First Steps towards Feminist Regional Organizing

This last section presents the first steps towards building regional feminist organizing as shared and recommended by participants throughout the study. The first and most important recommendation was to begin with small and incremental steps before moving towards formal and structured planning and organizing. Such steps would include the **organization of initial meetings that bring together feminist activists from different countries of the region**, with the aim of providing spaces for feminists to get to know each other, and for engaging in conversations and discussions around the possibilities of building collective work. This recommendation came in response to the context of fragmentation that marks feminist spaces, and from the need for activists to get together and develop relationships of trust among each other. Participants noted that the first meetings can take place in online and virtual spaces to facilitate broad participation, which can then be followed by face-to-face meetings that are dedicated to discussing and delving further into the goals, objectives, priorities and structures of regional feminist organizing.

With regards to the steps related to coordination and the management of the work, some participants emphasized the importance of having a specific feminist organization take on the role of coordination to ensure sustainability, and the allocation of the needed financial and human resources. Others preferred working outside of organizational structures arguing that this allows for greater flexibility and helps avoid the constraints that organizational structures may impose on feminist discourse and practice. Within this context, participants supported a collective and participatory coordination model that is shared among member groups & individuals, as it aligns more closely with feminist principles. They also stressed the importance of exploring alternative funding models that are more independent and sustainable. As a first step, participants suggested **reviewing existing organizational and funding models adopted by feminist networks and alliances** in different regions and contexts, with the aim of learning from and building upon these experiences. Finally, participants underscored the **importance of taking the time needed to build a solid foundation** for feminist organizing grounded in shared values and a common vision. Several participants proposed developing a **founding charter** that articulates the core principles, values and definitions that would guide regional work.



06 Sixth: Concluding Remarks

The study shows that the **importance** of feminist work in the SWANA region lies in its close **engagement with the lives and realities of women and marginalized communities, as well as its interaction with the dominant** political, economic, social, and colonial contexts shaping the region. With regards to regional feminist organizing, the research highlights the various efforts led by feminists to build connections with other feminists across the region, the multiple shapes such initiatives and efforts have taken, and the opportunities and challenges that cross-border organizing is currently facing within different contexts.

Amidst ongoing challenges, the study reveals a general consensus among feminist activists on **the urgent need for building regional feminist organizing as a crucial space for breaking isolation, linking feminist struggles across the region, practicing solidarity among feminist groups**, and **producing collective knowledge that is grounded in lived realities & capable of confronting political, economic, and colonial forms of oppression**.

Recent experiences **- such as the cross-border feminist strike, the Uprising of Women in the Arab World campaign, and the Tal'at movement -** demonstrate that regional feminist organizing is both possible and effective, particularly when it is rooted in feminist principles such as decentralization, intersectionality, care, and collective action. At the same time, these experiences highlight key obstacles that hinder the sustainability of such efforts, including the repressive contexts and practices confronting feminists in the region, which expose them to violence, surveillance, and, in some cases, detention and torture; the absence of collective organizing mechanisms that provide guidelines for addressing internal divisions within feminist spaces; the lack of accountability frameworks; and the scarcity of independent and sustainable funding.

In that sense, the suggestion for building regional feminist organizing opens possibilities for thinking about alternative structures & practices

06 Sixth: Concluding Remarks

for feminist work, that are built on values of solidarity and collective work and that break from mainstream and dominant practices. As emphasized repeatedly by participants, **the first steps towards building a regional feminist alliance include allowing sufficient time for building strong foundations and mutual trust among feminist activists, and for elaborating a collective founding charter that articulates the political and ethical values guiding feminist organizing and serves as a common reference point for participating members**. In this context, it is important for a regional feminist alliance to take into consideration the differences in priorities for different feminist groups that are shaped by their local contexts and provide space for acknowledging these differences in the process of building impactful and effective work. Finally, learnings from previous experiences of regional feminist work have shed light on **the importance of documentation of organizing experiences as a primary source of knowledge that provides insights into the factors that contribute towards the success or failure** of this type of work – and that **allows for transmitting these insights to different groups**.

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